

the Central Provinces.

In January 1948, Ingen requested the Bombay Natural History Society (BNHS) to publish a record of this hunt. It was left to the editors to call out the act—and they did. "The editors were so nauseated by the account of this slaughter that their first impulse was to consign it to the wastepaper basket. Its publication here is intended in the nature of an impeachment rather than any desire on their part to condone or extol the deed," they stated in the published record. The journal castigated the ruler, challenging his claims of being a sportsman—like most Indian princes of that era—and also for being ignorant of the status of the cheetah in India. "...So wanton as to destroy such a rare and harmless animal when he [the ruler] has the phenomenal good fortune to run into not one but three together—probably the last remnants of a dying race," wrote the editors. The lament was justified as the cheetah wasn't seen again.

WITH A CENTRAL BUDGET OF Rs 91.65 CRORE AND Rs 50 CRORE AS CSR FUNDS FROM IOC, THERE'S A LOT RIDING ON THE PROJECT'S SUCCESS

can say I have not seen any habitat in India that has the prey to support free-ranging cheetah. What's being brought is an exotic species," Thapar tells INDIA TODAY. That too, one extremely fragile, even on home turf. "Even in the eastern Serengeti, which has 1-1.5 million prey animals for the cheetah, the mortality rate of cheetah cubs is 90 per cent," he argues. Kuno, with villages and feral dogs all around it, would be hostile territory. He would rather that the precious funds being spent here be utilised to conserve species like the tiger, lion and elephant that currently face grave risks.

On the other side of the debate are conservationists like M.K. Rajnitsinh, a former IAS officer and director, wildlife, Government of India, who argue that cheetahs are no way alien to India. "If Humayun brought the cheetah to India, what explains their depiction on rock art thousands of years ago?" Indeed, sites like Khairabad and Khairvai record the beast—if not with the same majesty as San rock art from South Africa, in full flight, with its unmistakable rudder-like tail held up for balance. "Also, Akbar had thousands of cheetahs in his inventory. They must have run a very successful conservation programme," he adds, the rhetoric flowing high. "And cheetahs are known to survive in forests too. The last cheetah to be shot was in fact in a Sal forest, not a grassland," adds Ranjitsinh, whom the Supreme Court had in 2020 appointed head of the expert committee to oversee the cheetah's translocation.

Kuno has about 30 chital per sq. km, a density that rivals many well-managed tiger reserves, and this is when it doesn't have a single tiger. The overall prey base would "suffice for around 20 cheetahs. Once the areas around Kuno recover, we can possibly support up to 40," says Dr Y.V. Jhala, dean, WII. "And Kuno has no feral dogs or villages in its 750 sq. km. We plan to have a managed meta population. Our viability assessment suggests a very high probability of success, and factors in all the doubts raised," he adds. The project has been designed in accordance with guidelines set by the IUCN (International Union for Conservation of Nature) Reintroduction Group, and accounts for a probable mortality as high as 50 per cent.

If survival is the question, Project Cheetah itself had to face up to that challenge. This stage has come 50 years after the idea was first mooted, in the teeth of opposition from a section of wild-lifers—and after crossing a curious legal tangle. The latest chapter in the translocation story, which began in 2009 under the UPA's environment minister Jairam Ramesh, ran into hostile turf almost right away. In 2013, persuaded by the naysayers, the Supreme Court halted it. In 2017, the National Tiger Conservation Authority sought a clarification, and it was only in January 2020 that the then Chief Justice of India, Justice Sharad Bobde, gave the go-ahead. "The bench exercised a great deal of caution," Justice Bobde tells INDIA TODAY. "The court agreed to it on an experimental basis, after looking into the pros and cons. I felt the cheetah will do well in the parts where it is being introduced, as they aren't alien there."

And thus India embarked on its attempt to rescript natural history. Surrounding it may be a forest of sounds, some favourable, others hostile. But those invested in it go beyond local tribal populations who see new avenues of employment, or hoteliers who spy some new prey in the form of interested amateurs. The story relates to the entirety of life systems, ultimately. India has had a patchy history—wanton hunting, deforestation and habitat loss to mining and infrastructure continue to this day, but there are also success stories. Project Tiger, especially, has bounced back from the lows of the early 2000s, with wild populations more than doubling to 2,967 by 2019. Kuno itself has other dilemmas to solve. Its lion relocation plan is still not extinct—a recently painted mural at Tiktoli, an entry point to the reserve, depicts a lion too. But, for now, the story is all about the only big cat in the world that does not roar. It's also the only cat with non-retractable claws—they dig into the ground to function as a sprinter's spikes, as the very scene that thrilled ancient artists across continents unfolds once again. ■